

of Petroleum on the second floor of Shastri Bhavan. Beyond the obvious, the judgement made it possible for Anil to lay claim on gas over and above the 28 mmscmd that he was battling for. The MOU categorically divides all prospective gas belonging to RIL's share in a ratio of 60 for Mukesh and 40 for Anil. Suddenly, the Government of India, which had maintained its neutrality, was now a party. It moved a special leave petition in the Supreme Court where, in a surprisingly strong plea, it said "knowing fully well that gas does not belong to them and that the contracting companies are bound by the terms of the psc the respondents have appropriated through the MOU, in a surreptitious and unauthorised manner, the entire gas treating the same as their personal and family property". The Government then went on to dub the MOU (in reference to the gas deal) as blatantly illegal and pleaded that it be declared "null and void".

It was akin to waving the red rag to a bull, or to Anil. Instinctively, he invoked free marketeer Dhirubhai and attacked his brother and the Government for re-introducing the licence permit raj through the back door, via



ANIL AMBANI WITH AMAR SINGH AND MULAYAM SINGH YADAV AT DADRI PROJECT FOUNDATION CEREMONY

the utilisation and pricing policy. The hyper-active Anil, known for his contacts across the political spectrum, worked the wires. Briefings, dossiers and special presentations were organised for bureaucrats and politicians. Faced with the wild charge of appropriating sovereign assets, Anil quickly converted the AGM of RNRL into a campaign platform answering a series of questions in his speech providing his shareholders and eager camera crews an FAQ on the imbroglio. Within 10 days he has written twice to the prime minister, to the petroleum minister and to Power Minister Sushil Kumar Shinde. In his missive to him, he urged the ministry to fight for NTPC,

on how they stood to lose Rs 20,000 crore if they didn't fight for the price of \$2.34 per mmBtu.

It is virtually spy vs spy out there in Lutyens Delhi. Last week there were rumours about details of hawala transactions and foreign accounts being passed to the PMO for an inquiry. Every move is checked and mated with a counter move. As soon as the RIL camp floated a story of a former chairman of NTPC joining the ADA Group, the rivals posted a riposte on an officer joining the RIL-sponsored Observer Research Foundation soon after presiding over gas the pricing formula. Replete with intel and innuendo, charge and counter charge, the battle is live on news chan-

INTERVIEW ■ ANIL AMBANI

"I am pained that under Mukesh's leadership RIL is trying to renege on its contract."

ADA Group Chairman. Anil Ambani spoke with INDIA TODAY on the gas imbroglio.

Q. Why are you asking for gas now when you can't use it in any of your power plants? As we understand, the MoU does not allow for trading but only captive consumption.

A. RIL has created this situation by refusing to execute a bankable gas supply agreement, which is essential for project viability and implementation. I'm only interested in uninterrupted and assured supply for our gas-based power projects. RIL's malafide conduct in renegeing on its corporate agreement has delayed the implementation.

Q. You have raised over Rs 31,000 crore for your power projects but there is no visible progress on your projects. You are utilising this money elsewhere.

A. I wish we had Rs 31,000 crore. You

are referring to debt financing commitments made by banks and financial institutions for our projects to be disbursed over the next five years. We have the equity funding that is deployed in 100 per cent safe fixed income mutual funds. Our first power plant of 1,200 MW at Rosa in Uttar Pradesh will become operational in the next few months, ahead of schedule. Progress on our 4,000 MW Sasan NPP is also far ahead of schedule.

Q. Why isn't MDA promising gas to you?

A. I am pained that under my respected elder brother's leadership, RIL is doing everything in its power to renege on its binding commitment to supply gas to us. This is so contrary to the fundamental values of trust and integrity that my father Dhirubhai Ambani stood for and on the basis of which he founded Reliance. Whatever the reason... I have no idea what it is... corporate greed, personal vendetta, misguided advise from the 3Cs—*chelas, chanchas* and cronies.